



Parachute drop

In November 1953, the French parachuted troops into Dien Bien Phu to establish a fortified base. Called Operation Castor, the attack overwhelmed Viet Minh soldiers on the ground.

Battle stations

The French base was on a plain ringed by hills. While the French dug trenches and built strongpoints to defend their vital airstrip, the Viet Minh occupied the high ground, installing Chinese-supplied artillery and anti-aircraft guns.

By February 1954, French aircraft flying in and out of the base were coming under heavy fire. Full-scale fighting began on March 13. By then, France had 11,000 troops in Dien Bien Phu, led by Colonel Christian de Castries. They included French paratroopers, Foreign Legionnaires, colonial soldiers from North Africa, and elements of the Vietnamese National Army. Facing them were 50,000 Viet Minh supported by 105 mm and 155 mm artillery.

The first Viet Minh attacks rapidly overran two French forward positions, codenamed Beatrice and Gabrielle. The intensity of the Viet Minh artillery barrage astonished the defenders, whose counterfire proved ineffectual. By March 17, the airstrip was unusable and resupply had to be by parachute.

10,000 The number of soldiers on the French side who were taken prisoner at Dien Bien Phu. Only one in three of them survived captivity.